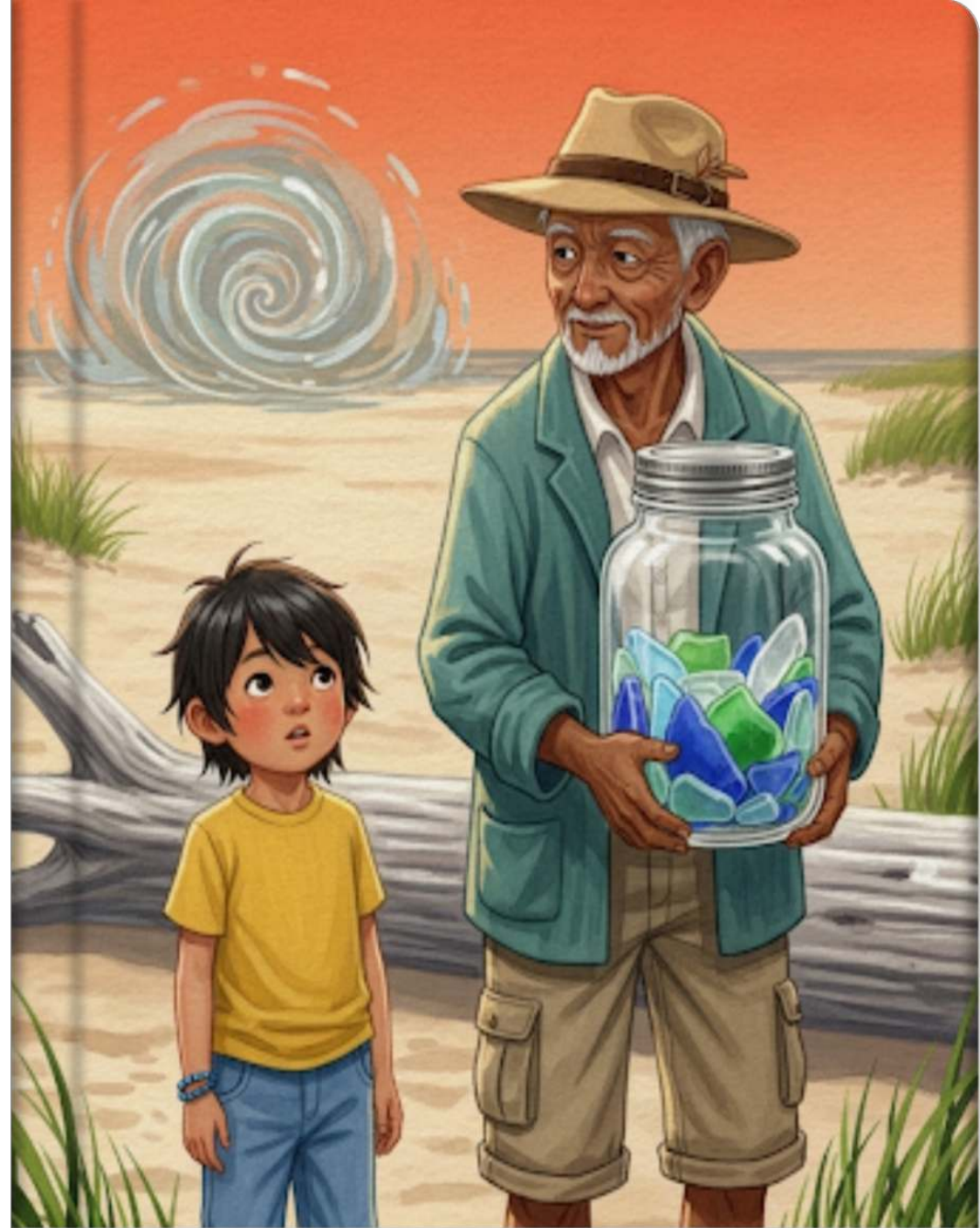




The Jar of Ocean Jewels - Anger Edition

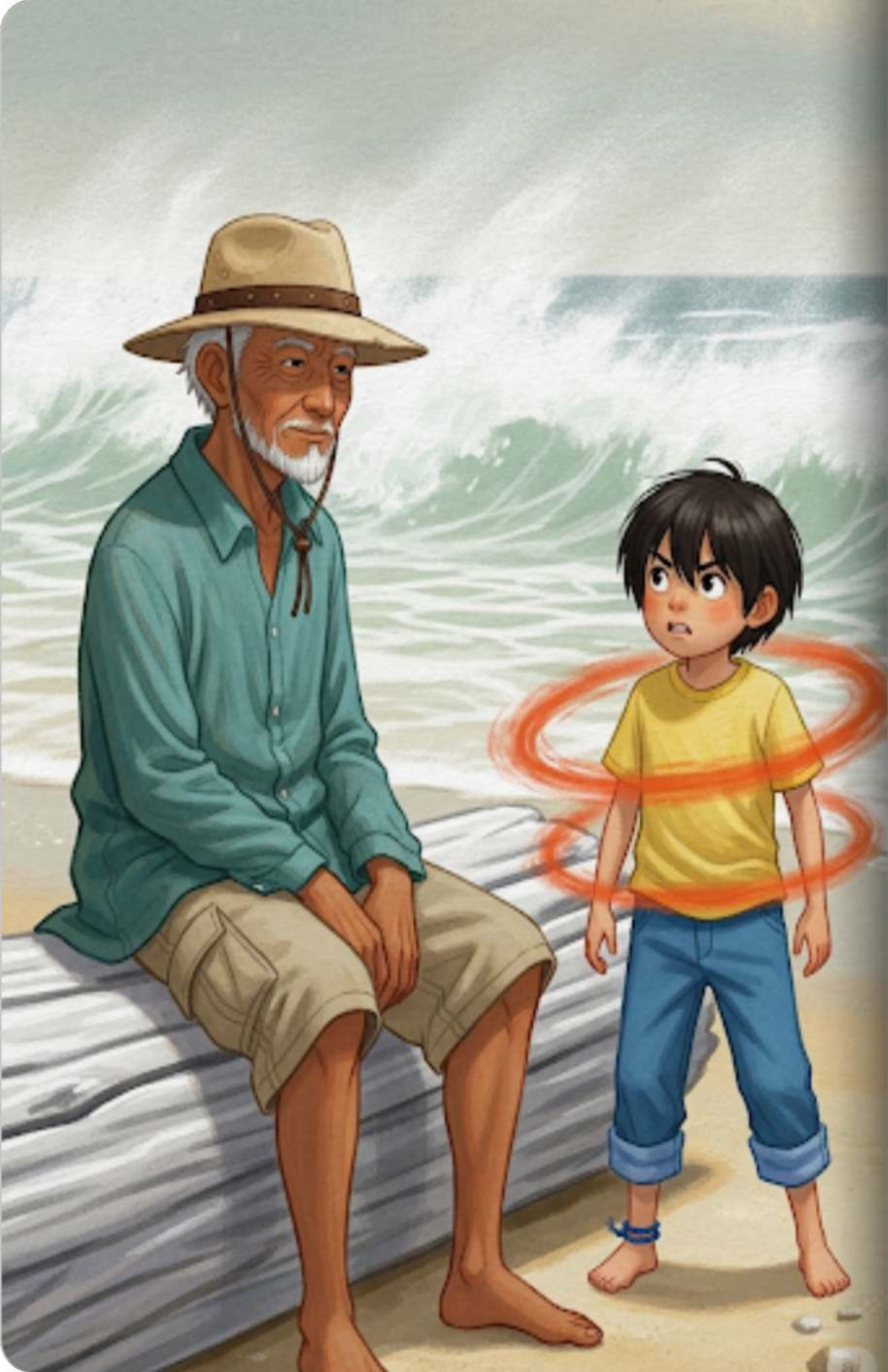
By Michael Mendez



The sun was hot on the sand, but Kai felt even hotter. He felt a "Storm Tide" rising in his chest—a churning, bubbling energy that made his hands want to squeeze into fists. Soren walked beside him, watching the white foam crash against the jagged rocks. "Anger is like a summer storm, Kai," Soren said calmly. "It is loud and it is powerful, but even the storm has its place in the sea."



The "Storm Tide" made Kai want to stomp and shout. He saw a pile of driftwood and felt like kicking it into the waves. The world felt too loud, too bright, and much too unfair. He stood at the edge of the water, watching the waves crash and shatter into a thousand pieces. He felt like he was about to shatter, too.



Soren sat down on a piece of driftwood, leaving plenty of space for Kai. He didn't tell Kai to calm down or be quiet. He just watched the spray fly. "When the waves are this high, the sand gets stirred up and the water gets cloudy," Soren said. "We can't see the bottom when we are splashing, Kai. We have to wait for the bubbles to pop."



Soren reached into his pocket and pulled out the glass jar. He searched through the colorful pieces until he found one that was a bright, fiery orange-red. "This is 'Fire Glass,'" Soren said, holding it up so it caught the sun. "It's the rarest kind. It didn't become this beautiful by being soft; it became this way because it survived the heat and the roughest currents."



In a small, rocky tide pool, they found a pufferfish named Puka. Puka was agitated, having been startled by a falling stone. He was puffed up into a giant, prickly ball, his little fins wiggling fast. Kai looked at the round, spiky fish and saw exactly how he felt inside—puffed up, sharp, and ready to poke anyone who got too close.



Puka stayed puffed up for a long time, but then he began to let out a long, slow stream of bubbles. Slowly, his spikes tucked away, and his body became small and smooth again. He took a deep breath of the clear water and swam into a shady crevice between the rocks. He wasn't a prickly ball anymore; he was just a fish again.



Soren looked at Kai. "The pufferfish knows that holding all that air is tiring. He has to let it out so he can swim again. Try to breathe with the tide, Kai. Big breath in as the water comes up, long breath out as the foam goes away." Kai took a deep breath, and as he exhaled, he felt the "Storm Tide" in his chest begin to ebb.



As the heat in his chest cooled, Kai spotted something bright nestled between two grey pebbles. He reached down and picked up a piece of sea glass that was the color of a glowing coal. It was strong and bold. He realized his anger wasn't a monster; it was just a lot of energy that needed a place to go.



The sun began to set, turning the whole sky the same orange-red color as the jewel in the jar. The water was steady now, a rhythmic heartbeat against the shore. Kai walked back with Soren, feeling the power of the ocean in his legs, but the peace of the tide in his heart. He knew the storm would return one day, but he knew how to breathe until the water cleared.